

How to Use This Atlas

THE BIRD ATLAS IS ARRANGED in order of continent—the Americas, Europe, Africa, Asia, Australasia, and Antarctica. A double-page, such as the one on Africa (right), introduces the continent as a whole. This is followed by pages showing the main places where birds live—their habitats—within that continent.

On any page you can see which continent it is about by looking at the heading in the top left-hand corner; the habitat featured is given in the top right-hand corner. The sample pages here show how the information is presented on the two main types of pages—continental and habitat pages—and explain the maps, symbols, and abbreviations used.

Where on Earth?

The red shaded area on this globe shows the location of the habitat featured on the page. The shaded area on this globe shows the position of Central America and the Caribbean within the Americas.



Bird symbols

Symbols of each of the birds illustrated on the page show the main areas where each species lives, although some birds live all over the region. By looking at the key, you can identify the birds and then find them on the map.

Continental pages

These pages introduce the continent and give an overview of the climate, landscape, main bird habitats, typical birds, and amazing birds to be found there. A large map shows the size of the continent, its position on the globe, and major geographical features. There is usually a feature showing how the position of the continent has changed over millions of years.

AFRICA

Africa is the second largest continent in the world. It is mostly desert, with only a few fertile areas. The Sahara desert is the largest in the world. The Nile river is the longest in Africa. The continent is home to many amazing birds, including the ostrich, the secretary bird, and the kori bustard.

Climate and landscape
Africa has a hot climate, with very little rain. The landscape is mostly desert, with some savanna and a few mountains. The Great Rift Valley is a series of lakes and rivers that runs through the center of the continent.

Amazing birds of Africa
Ostrich
The ostrich is the largest bird in the world. It can run as fast as a horse and can live in the desert. It has a long neck and a small head.

Secretary bird
The secretary bird is a large bird that lives in the savanna. It has long legs and a long neck. It is known for its ability to catch snakes and lizards.

Kori bustard
The kori bustard is a large bird that lives in the savanna. It has a long neck and a small head. It is known for its ability to catch snakes and lizards.

Other birds
There are many other birds in Africa, including the vulture, the eagle, and the falcon. Each bird has its own special adaptations for life in the African environment.

Central America and the Caribbean

The rich bird life of Central America is partly due to the landscapes in the region, which vary from dry grassland on the west coast to alpine meadows in the middle and lush rainforest and swamps on the eastern coasts. Central America forms a narrow bridge linking North and South America, so birds from both continents mix there. Many North American birds migrate to the warmer climate of Central America for the winter. The Caribbean islands are the tips of mountains buried in very deep water. The birds here are either strong fliers that were able to reach the islands or they were blown there accidentally by strong winds. Several unique species have developed on the islands: the tody family, for example, is found nowhere else in the world.

Oilbird
(Heteronotus carolinensis)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (49 cm)
Young oilbirds do not fly until they are about four months old so they grow incredibly fat. People used to make oil from their fatty flesh, which is how the bird got its name. The oilbird lives in caves and finds its way in the darkness by making clicking sounds. The time it takes for the sound to bounce back lets the bird work out how far away walls or objects are. At night, it flies out of the cave to feed on oily fruits. Its good sense of smell and excellent eyesight help it find food.

Resplendent quetzal
(Pharosclerus mexicanus)
Length: 1 ft 4 in (40 cm)
The male has shiny feathers and a long tail. The female is dull colored and does not have a long tail. The male grows new tail feathers each breeding season. They can be up to 2 ft (60 cm) long.

Crested oropendola
(Pipilo maculatus)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (48 cm)
Crested oropendolas live in groups and nest together, too. They can build up to 100 nests in just one tree. This probably helps protect the eggs and young from predators, as the birds can warn each other of danger. The male has a spectacular courtship display to attract a female. He makes a series of loud gurgling sounds while flapping his wings and leaning forward so far that he almost falls off his perch.

Three-wattled bellbird
(Procnitis tricarunculata)
Length: 1 ft 10 in (58 cm)
Male bellbirds make one of the loudest calls of any bird. They advertise for a female by producing an explosive "bock" noise. This call can be heard 0.6 miles (1 km) away. The female builds the nest and looks after the young. She is a dull color to camouflage her while she sits on the nest.

Puerto Rican tody
(Tody tinnunculus)
Length: 5 in (12 cm)
This tody lives in woods and forests and feeds by pouncing on insects from a perch. When it flies, it makes a whirring noise with its wings. During the breeding season, the tody uses its bill to dig tiny nesting burrows in a bank, like its relative the kingfisher. There are four other species of Caribbean tody.

Sunbittern
(Eurypyga helias)
Length: 1 ft 10 in (48 cm)
During its courtship display, the sunbittern spreads its wings to show off the patches of orange and yellow on its feathers. These look like the colors of a sky at sunset, which is how the bird got its name. At other times, the mottled colors on the feathers camouflage the bird as it searches for food along stream banks in woodland areas. It catches fish, insects, and frogs with its long, sharp bill.

Black skimmer
(Rynchops niger)
Length: 1 ft 6 in (46 cm)
The black skimmer has a strange bill—the bottom part is about one-third longer than the top part. To find food, the skimmer flies over shallow water with its bill open. When its bill hits a small fish or crustacean, the skimmer snaps the top bill down to trap its prey.

ABBREVIATIONS USED IN THE ATLAS:

Metric	Imperial
mm	millimeter
cm	centimeter
m	meter
km	kilometer
sq km	square kilometers
kph	kilometers per hour
kg	kilogram
°C	celsius
in	inch
ft	foot
mph	miles per hour
sq miles	square miles
lb	pound
°F	fahrenheit

Scale

You can use this scale to figure out the size of the area shown on the map.

Black skimmer (Rynchops niger)

Latin names

Scientists have given each bird species a Latin name. This means that everyone can use the same name to identify birds, no matter what language they speak. A bird's Latin name is divided into two parts. The first is a group name given to a number of similar birds. For example, *Rynchops* is the group name for skimmers. The second part identifies the particular species of bird and often tells you something more specific about it. In this case *niger*, the Latin word for "black."